

Nujoo Workshop — Pre-Session Orientation

Korean Traditional Jang Culture and Its Contemporary Application

Date: June 29, 2026, 13:00

Venue: Mak Seoul

Host: Kim Won-il, Chairman, Tomorrow's Table

Summary

This session covered the full breadth of Korean traditional jang (fermented sauce/paste) culture—including meju (fermented soybean blocks) and ganjang (soy sauce)—with the aim of re-establishing its cultural, manufacturing, and aging philosophy, and exploring its potential to expand within contemporary dining and fine-dining contexts. The lecture explained that jang originated from the desire to consume salt in a more palatable way, and traced its history from early meat-and-fish-based jang (yukjang) to bean-based jang (dujang). The instructor emphasized moving beyond the industrialized, standardized notion of the “100% soybean block” meju, noting that in the past, meju was made from a wide variety of ingredients and shapes using regional specialties such as acorns and sweet potatoes, and that sizes varied according to climate.

The session also compared the characteristics and production methods of the different salts that determine jang flavor (sun-dried salt, boiled salt, bamboo salt, etc.), and explained in detail other contributing factors such as water, beans, climate, and vessels. It addressed differences in production methods by ganjang type (Korean-style / brewed / blended soy sauce, and amino-acid liquid), changes in value according to aging period, and the historical background behind the loss of soybean varietal diversity (Japanese colonial rule and industrialization). Finally, it introduced recent trends including cases of renowned chefs studying jang and discussions on revising food-code regulations (reclassifying amino-acid liquid as a “sauce”), presenting the potential for meju to be used as a creative fermentation ingredient beyond a mere raw material.

1. The Origins and Re-establishment of Jang Culture

(1) The Invention of Jang and Its Historical Evolution

1. Jang was invented in East Asia as a way to consume salt more palatably than eating it directly, and is a product reflecting the human pursuit of umami (savory flavor).
2. It began as yukjang (meat jang); “eoyukjang” (fish-and-meat jang) can be viewed as a single “ecosystem” in which diverse microorganisms coexist.
3. It later evolved into the era of dujang (bean jang), with beans as the main ingredient; mixed forms combining meat and meju also existed.

(2) Re-establishing Meju Culture

- Seasonal independence: Meju need not be confined to a specific season or ritual (e.g., making jang in the first lunar month). A culture is needed in which meju is made and used with seasonal ingredients at any time. The seasonal notion reinforced during industrialization is only part of the tradition, not an absolute norm.
- Versatility: Beyond being merely an ingredient for doenjang (soybean paste) and gochujang (red pepper paste), meju is a creative fermentation ingredient applicable to a wide range of jang varieties and menus. Like koji (*Aspergillus* mold) in Western kitchens, it holds great potential for use in fine dining.

2. The Diversity of Meju: Ingredients and Forms

(1) Meju Ingredients

The modern perception of “meju = 100% soybeans” is a product of industrialization. In the past, meju was made by blending regional specialties such as acorns, sweet potatoes, and various grains with soybeans.

- Acorn meju: Made by steaming and grinding processed acorns together with soybeans.
- Sweet potato meju: Made by mixing in dried sweet potato at a ratio of 10–20% (mainly in southern regions).

(2) Form and Size of Meju

4. Closely related to regional climate.
 - Southern regions (hot and humid): High risk of spoilage, so meju is made small to ferment quickly.
 - Northern regions (cold and dry): Low risk of spoilage, so meju is made large to build a bigger “home” for microorganisms and enrich the flavor (e.g., Gangwon-do,

Paju).

5. Early Joseon-era texts record various forms, such as meju with holes pierced through it like a doughnut for stringing and storage.

3. Factors That Determine Flavor: Salt, Water, Environment

(1) Types and Roles of Salt

6. Salt is the key ingredient determining the flavor and preservability of jang; there is a tendency to make jang saltier the further south one goes.
7. Sun-dried salt (cheonilyeom): Rich in minerals and considered good for fermentation, so favored by artisans, though concerns about environmental hormones may arise. It is sometimes used after removing bitterness for three or more years.
8. Boiled salt (jayeom): A traditional method of raising salinity using tidal-flat soil and then boiling; it has less bitterness and a sweeter taste.
9. Bamboo salt (jukyeom): Salt made by placing sun-dried salt in bamboo tubes and roasting it repeatedly at high temperatures to remove impurities.
10. Others: Includes melted salt (high-temperature dissolution) and Hanju salt (refined salt, sometimes favored due to concerns over marine pollution).

(2) Water, Beans, Climate, and Vessels

Regional water quality and soybean variety also have an effect, but the most decisive factors are the overall fermentation environment—the climate and local conditions (temperature, humidity) of the region where the meju ages, and vessel management.

(3) Regionality (Terroir)

Jang is differentiated through the interaction of a region's air, water, and beans. Jeju-style ganjang is an example of securing a flavor distinct from the mainland by applying Jeju beans, meju, and a volcanic-soil environment.

4. The Jang-Making and Aging Process

(1) Basic Process

After harvesting beans in October–November, meju is made in winter and fermented for about two months. It is then submerged in 18–20% brine for an additional two months of

aging, after which it is matured in earthenware jars (onggi).

(2) Aging Period and Value

A minimum of one year of aging is recommended, and there is a significant flavor difference between one-year and three-year aging. Flavor deepens with aging periods such as 2, 3, 5, and 10 years, and future pricing may be set in proportion to this.

5. Types of Ganjang and Contemporary Issues

- Korean-style ganjang (Joseon ganjang): A traditional fermentation method using meju.
- Brewed soy sauce (yangjo ganjang): A Japanese-style method in which cultures are inoculated onto defatted soybeans, etc., and fermented for about six months.
- Amino-acid liquid: Soybean protein chemically decomposed with acid; unrelated to fermentation.
- Blended soy sauce (honhap ganjang): A product mixing brewed soy sauce and amino-acid liquid; widely available in the market.
- Discussion on food-code revision: The Ministry of Food and Drug Safety is moving to reclassify amino-acid liquid from the soy-sauce category to the “sauce” category. Product names such as “jinganjang” may be retained, but the food-type labeling will change.

6. The Intersection of Dining/Fine Dining and Jang

- Chefs' learning and reinterpretation: A growing number of chefs at renowned restaurants are learning about jang and reinterpreting it with their own regional ingredients.
- The potential of meju: If a culture of handling jang like a wine sommelier spreads, meju could become a key ingredient for creative menu development in Korean fine dining.

7. The History and Challenges of Soybean Varieties

(1) Background of Diversity Loss

The Korean Peninsula was the place of origin of the soybean, but through the Japanese colonial period, industrialization, and yield-focused agricultural policy, native soybeans declined sharply and varieties became standardized.

(2) Current Challenges

To restore the regionality and individuality of jang, the

conservation of native soybean varieties and the recovery of diversity are important.

Assignments

11. Establish a plan for meju-making and jang-making practice: Harvest October–November 2026 → make meju December 2026 → brine submersion (18–20%) February 2027 → age for at least one year until December 2027, then conduct a comparative tasting. (Includes hands-on participation in making meju directly, based on the lecture content.)
12. Salt sourcing (procurement and discovery) and comparative experiments: Make jang under identical conditions while varying the type (sun-dried salt, boiled salt, etc.) and bittarn-removal method, and compare taste and aroma.
13. Controlled experiments on regional water, vessels, and environmental variables: Compare fermentation results while varying water, jar type, and environmental conditions. (Includes designing meju forms that account for the climate of one's own region.)
14. Compose a ganjang-type tasting set: Conduct a blind tasting of four types—Korean-style ganjang, brewed soy sauce, blended soy sauce, and amino-acid liquid (sauce category)—and study their production methods and labeling.
15. Fine-dining collaboration pilot: Develop three meju/jang-based course-menu proposals (sauces, pickles, etc.) with local chefs and collect feedback.
16. Jeju-style benchmarking: Analyze recipes reflecting the Jeju bean, meju, and volcanic-soil environment, and review feasibility of reproduction.
17. Native soybean survey: Collaborate with local farms and seed banks to collect native soybean varieties, cultivate small quantities, and compile data.
18. Monitoring food-code revision trends: Track developments related to the Ministry of Food and Drug Safety's soy-sauce/sauce reclassification and prepare a labeling guide.

